without a prepared text. This ability to speak extempore is something he learned from Naval, who was a very humorous and captivating orator. Ratan says: ‘For many years, I was afraid to speak. I still am, but much less so. And now I find myself less afraid to stand up in a moment and make a couple of statements, and this has come from my father.’

Soonoo eventually got remarried to Sir Jamsetjee Jejeebhoy. They had three daughters, Shireen, Deanna and Geeta (fondly called Geetie). Geeta passed away in 2011. Ratan is quite close to Shireen and Deanna.

The ‘Guiding Light’

In Lady Tata, Ratan found a benefactor extraordinaire. She was the respected and powerful elder stateswoman and matriarch of the Tata empire, and she and Ratan meant the world to each other. For him, there is no one who can even remotely compare in importance to his grandmother. She was his ‘guiding light’, as he proudly declares. He had a special name for her: MyG. Ratan says, ‘She was the centre of my universe.’ He and Lady Tata would spend hours together and she would narrate stories about her life in England—how she went horse riding, her experiences around the world—with Ratan listening starry-eyed. Ratan says: ‘There was a hall in Tata House where there was a table. I would find a secret drawer in it, find a picture and take it to my grandmother, and she would weave a story around it. I had no archival sense since I was still in school. I would find something here, something there, and I would take it to her, and she would tell me a story related to it.’ As his sisters say, ‘she was the one person who steered all his values’ and her ‘strong’ sense of ‘what is right and wrong’ shaped his personality.

Ratan remembers spending all his free time at his grandmother’s ‘feet’, listening to her stories and absorbing their essence and moral underpinnings. She also narrated tales of her meetings with the stalwarts of the Indian freedom struggle, including Mahatma Gandhi, who often stayed at the York House. These accounts greatly influenced Ratan.

In terms of physical comfort, his grandmother ensured that he had the best, though the luxurious lifestyle utterly embarrassed Ratan. There were nearly forty servants at home to cater to virtually every whim and fancy of its occupants. When he needed a car, Lady Tata would ensure that Ratan travelled in her huge Rolls-Royce, Delage or the sixteen-cylinder Cadillacs.